Trafalgar Square in central London. He was ostensibly a jute exporter from India, but actually the senior-most member of‘the band of three’.

Malik was regarded as one of the agency’s best spies. He had spent a month meticulously working on an operational blue print for Mission Fiji, which aimed to disrupt and dismantle Fiji’s military regime. When the plan was finally discussed with top officials, there was a mixed sense of scepticism and awe. They were unsure whether the team was capable of conducting such a daredevil covert operation in two months.

According to Shekhawat, Malik had wanted six months to complete the operation. ‘But his seniors wanted a feel of the wind in the first two months before allowing him to operate further,’ said Shekhawat. ‘Malik pleaded that if Rabuka was to pay a price for what he was doing to the Indians, the spies needed more time. But the decision had already been made; Malik was to fight Rabuka and time together.’

On 21 March 1988, Malik entered the Quo Vadis restaurant on Dean Street. He was ushered into a private dining room where Samuel Cooper waited. Cooper flashed a broad smile and lunged forward to shake hands with Malik. Both said nothing until the attendant had left the room.

‘Malik, you said something urgent has come up. I hope you are not going to ruin my lunch,’ Cooper chuckled.

‘How much time and money do you think it will take to activate your contacts in Fiji?’ Malik asked.

‘Ohf’Cooper was surprised by the subject of Fiji. He had thought Malik needed help in London.